

Business Program Accreditation towards Continuous Improvement in Higher Education: A Case Study

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ABSTRACT

The growing scrutiny from the public and stakeholders in terms of quality as well as requirements from the government and the needs to keep up with regional and international developments have been the driving forces in facilitating the need for accreditation of higher education institutions in Vietnam, both at the institutional and the program levels. Accreditation has provided a framework for universities in general and business programs in particular to pursue high standards in quality towards continuous and sustainable development. This paper presents a case study of a private university in Vietnam which has recently achieved the accreditation status for its Business Administration program, as granted by the Accreditation Council for Business Schools and Programs (ACBSP), to present a process of accreditation and discuss the implications for continuous improvement of the program, faculty, and institution in the future. This information is expected to provide comprehensive understanding for not only university seeking ACBSP accredited but also other similar program-level accreditation.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Applied computing** → Education; Learning management systems.

KEYWORDS

Quality assurance, Program accreditation, Continuous improvement, ACBSP

ACM Reference Format:

Linh Thi My Nguyen, Anh Vi Tran, and Chien Thi Nguyen. 2020. Business Program Accreditation towards Continuous Improvement in Higher Education: A Case Study. In *2020 The 4th International Conference on Education and Multimedia Technology (ICEMT 2020)*, July 19–22, 2020, Kyoto, Japan. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 5 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3416797.3416820>

1 INTRODUCTION

In Vietnam, accreditation in higher education has been officially implemented less than two decades ago, and since requiring all higher education institutions and programs to be accredited in 2005, Vietnam's higher education has been keeping up with regional and global trends in quality assurance and accreditation, by establishing agencies in charge of accreditation activities, as well

as joining regional and international quality assurance networks [1]. At the institutional level, according to a study by Nguyen & Ta (2017), compulsory national accreditation has facilitated the design of management processes for continuous improvements in the universities with a high level of autonomy, specifically in terms of study program, teaching activities, lecturers and staff, students and student support, and facilities [2]. This has led to the necessity of and growing interest in pursuing institutional and program accreditation for all universities in Vietnam.

Furthermore, higher education in general and business education in particular are going under increasing scrutiny from the stakeholders (parents, sponsors, taxpayers etc.), as they are looking for justification for the investments into such education while tuition fees keep increasing; this fact has called for the need of accreditation, which is one way to assure stakeholders of quality and accountability [3]. Accreditation is defined by the Council for Higher Education Accreditation (CHEA) as a process of reviewing quality externally that higher education creates and utilizes to scrutinize colleges, universities and programs for the purpose of quality assurance and improvement [4]. On the other hand, according to the American Psychological Association, accreditation is both a status and a process [5]. By achieving the status of accreditation, it is understood that an institution has met the quality standards set by the accrediting body; while accreditation as a process expresses that the academic program is committed to self and external evaluation and continuous pursuit of quality in education and training [5].

According to Sywelem & Witte (2009), some of the functions served by accreditation are as follows [6]:

- To verify that established standards are met by the institution or program;
- To assist prospective students in making the decision among the choices of institutions;
- To assist institutions in terms of making the decision of accepting credit transfers;
- To help identify institutions and programs to receive investment of public and private funds;
- To set self-improvement goals for programs that are not yet up to standard and boost a rise in standards among institutions;
- To engage faculty and staff in the evaluation and planning of the institution and program;
- To set criteria for professional certification and licensure and for upgrading courses.

In the USA, there are three major accrediting organizations for business programs, which are the Association to Advance Collegiate Schools of Business (AACSB), the Accreditation Council for Business Schools and Programs (ACBSP), and the International Assembly of Collegiate Business Education (IACBE). Although established and based in the US, regarding the scope, all three of these

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ICEMT 2020, July 19–22, 2020, Kyoto, Japan

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ACM ISBN 978-1-4503-8837-5/20/07...\$15.00

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3416797.3416820>

business program accrediting bodies are international [3], thus leading to their growing adoption outside of the United States. The three accreditation bodies are also similar in the fact that the accreditation processes must be aligned with the mission of the school. In other words, whichever accreditation an institution might seek among the three organizations, it must have a mission, and all activities, curriculum, modes of instruction, course offerings, research productivity and facilities must be in line with the institution's strategy as stated in the mission statement [7].

However, the three accrediting organizations also have some differences in terms of guideline rigidity, faculty qualification requirements, and rigor of research or scholarly activity requirements [3]. The AACSB, having the longest history, is generally considered to be the most prestigious and rigorous accrediting body of business programs [8]. The AACSB as well as ACBSP are regarded to have more rigid standards of accreditation that must be achieved and maintained in order to be qualified for the status of accreditation, while the IACBE is more flexible in terms of these standards [3].

This is not to say that one accreditation is more valuable or "better" than another as each has a different focus; the AACSB is more research-oriented while the ACBSP and IACBE were established to appeal to teaching-oriented institutions [8]. Therefore, based on the strategic focus, each higher education institution can select an accreditation appropriate to their objectives.

Specifically, within the scope of this paper, the standards and processes of the ACBSP and how those have been applied in the process of gaining the accreditation status of a business program offered by a private university in Vietnam shall be looked into, followed by a discussion of how the institution may proceed towards sustainable development of its business programs upon attaining the ACBSP's accreditation status.

2 AN OVERVIEW OF ACBSP

The ACBSP was founded in 1988 at a time when the AACSB was still the only US accreditation organization for business programs, to target teaching-oriented institutions which were faced with difficulty in meeting the AACSB's research-focused requirements, although many of the ACBSP's standards were similar to those of the AACSB [8]. Specifically, institutions seeking to achieve the accreditation status from ACBSP must meet six standards as follows:

Standard 1. Leadership, which states that administrators (leaders) and the faculty must be personally involved in leading to create and sustain values, directions of the program, performance expectations, student focus, and a leadership system for the promotion of performance excellence [9].

Standard 2. Strategic planning, which states that programs must have a process in place to set strategic directions to improve the achievement of key performance requirements regarding the students and the program [9].

Standard 3. Student and stakeholder focus, which states that: "Business programs must have a systematic procedure to determine requirements and expectations of current and future students and stakeholders, including how the business programs enhances relationships with students and stakeholders and determines their satisfaction." [9].

Standard 4. Measurement and analysis of student learning and performance, which states that institutions and programs must conduct outcomes assessment and document the results and evidence that such results are serving the purpose of developing and enhancing the academic programs offered by the institution [9].

Standard 5. Faculty and staff focus, which states that the quality, number, and deployment of the faculty and staff are decisive factors in the programs' ability to fulfill their mission and meet their objectives [9].

Standard 6. Educational and business process management, which states that to meet academic demands, it is encouraged that institutions and programs be innovative and flexible in curriculum options, while still ensuring that students meet common professional requirements. Business programs must also have policies and procedures in place for the recruitment, admission, and retention of students [9].

ACBSP's teaching-oriented focus is reflected in the organization's guiding principles as follows [9]:

- ACBSP embraces the virtues of teaching excellence, with an emphasis to students on the importance of "learning how to learn".
- ACBSP considers research as a tool to facilitate an improvement in teaching, as institutions are encouraged to maintain a balance between teaching and research.
- ACBSP places an emphasis on the importance of high-quality performance in the classroom and the involvement of the faculty in the business world.
- ACBSP encourages creative approaches to teaching and the use of advanced technology.
- ACBSP seeks to provide leadership for the development of alliances globally to improve business curricula worldwide.
- ACBSP considers student outcomes assessment programs as essential in the improvement of business education's quality.
- ACBSP continually develops new services and activities to support institutions in achieving their strategic vision and mission.

Thus, ACBSP provides a framework for continuous improvement for business schools and programs that lean more towards teaching than research, while offering more flexibility and costing less financially than AACSB [10]. It then depends on individual institution to choose what accreditation framework best aligns with its mission, strategic focus, and direction. As of March 2020, only two universities in Vietnam (excluding international universities/programs) have achieved the accreditation status for their business programs from ACBSP (<https://www.acbspsearch.org/Home/Results>).

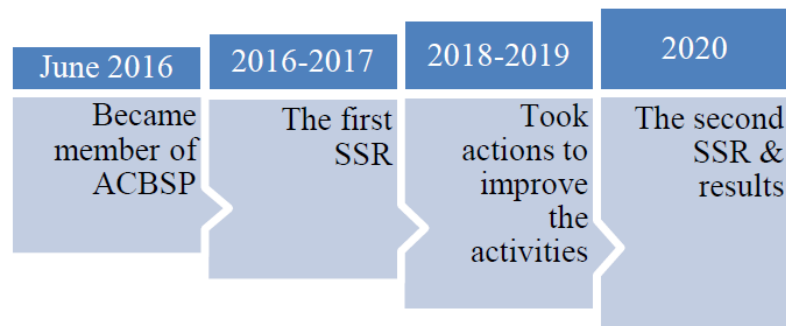
In this paper, the ACBSP accreditation's journey of one above-mentioned university is presented in order to provide comprehensive information for not only university seeking ACBSP accredited but also other similar program-level accreditations

3 THE JOURNEY FOR ACBSP ACCREDITATION AT A BUSINESS PROGRAM

In the first days of establishment, the X University was granted the license for educating undergraduate programs mainly focuses on providing IT-related bachelor programs. After a couple of years, it was granted the license for Business Administration degree under the Faculty of Business (FOB).

Table 1: Principles of program design

5 domains of knowledge	3 components in program structure
•Social awareness •Major knowledge, •Industry-oriented practice, •Foreign languages, and •Personal Development	•5 semesters of foundation, •1 (or 2) semester(s) of on-the-job training, and •3 semesters of specialization

**Figure 1: The X University's progress to ACBSP Accreditation**

The Business Administration program is designed 10 semesters/terms (exclude English preparation period), 15-16 weeks per semester and 45 hours per course. Its curriculum consists of 5 domains of knowledge, namely Social awareness, Major knowledge, Industry-oriented practice, Foreign languages, and Personal Development. Those domains help students to equip necessary basic knowledge and skills in the business field while pursuing specialization in a specific area. Besides, its program structure is demonstrated through the sandwich model which includes 3 components (5 semesters of foundation, 1 (or 2) semester(s) of on-the-job training, and 3 semesters of specialization) with 3 semesters per year (each semester lasts for 4 months) (as shown in Table 1 below).

To meet the X University's mission of providing global competitive advantages to massive learners as well as understanding the needs for academic quality of stakeholders, its administrators decided to participate in an international accreditation for Business Administration undergraduate program at its all two campuses in 2016.

Figure 1 above gives major milestones in the accreditation progress of the X University from 2016 to 2020. The details are provided at the session 3.1 and 3.2 as follow.

3.1 The First Self-Study Report (SSR)

In the duration from 2016 to the first haft of 2017, the X systematically implemented necessary tasks including:

(i) Forming a task force including members of the X's management board, FOB's managers, FOB faculties as well as members of the X's curriculum development division. This task force shows the engagement and great support from not only the faculty manager but also the institutional-level manager, which brings a lot

of favorable conditions for the afterward accreditation procedures, including financial matters. Additionally, the participation of curriculum development division which allocates experts in preparing a system of consistent and quality teaching and learning materials (from curriculum to lessons level) help the task force deeply understand the program, even its history.

(ii) Learning the best practices from other institutions which are accredited as well as increasing the awareness of faculties and related staff and departments through a series of internal and external seminar, workshop or training. It is truly important actions because it creates comprehensive understanding and support from faculties, staffs as well as recent students and alumni.

(iii) Applying for ACBSP membership. It is the prerequisite for accreditation according to ACBSP.

(iv) Continuous improvement. Regarding this step, under the advice of the X University's mentor (assigned by ACBSP), the X University in general and the FOB in particular amended and improved their activities to enhance training quality as well as meet the requirements of ACBSP. Some remarkable improvements were: Organizing external assessment of students' quality so that the FOB could use internal and external assessment results to redesign the curriculum, learning outcomes (at all levels), and teaching methods to meet recent global trends; Increasing the quality and quantity of faculties' research. That process took around one year to see the change as well as the improvement for the self-study report.

In the second haft of 2017, the X University submitted its self-study report (SSR) with necessary evidence to ACBSP Council via the system called ACBSP Campus Lab (<https://acbsp.campuslabs.com/>). At that time, the Council rejected the X University's self-study report at the very first stage – computer assessment because

Table 2: Number of classes taught by faculty at different level of qualification

	SU18		FA18		SP19		SU19	
	No.	%	No.	%	No.	%	No.	%
AQ	3	7.3%	14	27.5%	12	21%	23	53.5%
PQ	29	70.7%	34	66.7%	38	66.7%	17	39.5%
Min.	9	22%	3	5.8%	7	12.3%	3	7%

of three major matters: faculty qualification, faculty's science research activities, and long-term strategic plans.

Qualification of faculty members is the biggest challenge that the FOB has to deal with. As required by the ACBSP, at least 80 percent of the undergraduate credit hours should be taught by academically or professionally qualified faculty and at least 40 percent of the undergraduate credit hours are taught by academically qualified faculty (ACBSP, n.d.). At the first time submitting the self-study report, FOB did not well allocate the human resources to meet those requirements. FOB had to clearly plan to increase the percentage of credit hours be taught by academically or professionally qualified faculty for its afterward self-study report.

Faculty's science research activity is the second biggest challenge. Traditionally, the X University focus on focus on professional teaching so students can work in businesses immediately after graduation. Science research activity of faculty members and students are not properly developed. However, in the context of higher education, a higher institutions have to fulfill its functions including teaching, research and social services. Therefore, FOB committed to enhance research activities besides teaching and social services.

Last but not least, the ACBSP Council recommended that FOB should focus on its long-term strategic plans instead of short-term and middle-term plans. Instead of focusing only on financial-related targets, the FOB should pay attention to targets of academic activities, research as well as human resources development.

3.2 The Second Self-Study Report and Achievement

The X University and the FOB in 2018 tried to handle those three problems and prepare for another self-study report in 2019.

•Faculty qualification: Attracting academically and professionally qualified faculty members (both full-time and part-time faculty) by competitive income policies and attractive working environment. Thanks to that academically and professionally qualified faculty members reached the minimum requirement of ACBSP at the time of submitting the second self-study report.

Table 2 below shows the number of classes taught by faculty at different level of qualification. The number had some changes due to the X University's improvement in income policies and working environment. Especially, the percentage of classes taught by AQ increased impressively from 7.3% in semester SU18 to over 50% in semester SU19 to meet the requirement of ACBSP [9].

Specifically: SU18, FA18, SP19, SU19 are semester's codes at the X University. SP, SU, and FA stand for spring, summer, and fall, consecutively. And 18 & 19 stands for the years of 2018 and 2019.

AQ, PQ, and Min. are qualification levels divided by ACBSP. They are Academic Qualified, Professional Qualified, and Minimum Qualification, consecutively.

•Faculty's science research activities: Increasing the type and amount of financial aid for faculty members and students who do science researches.

•Long-term strategic plans matter: The X University and the FOB state clear and consistent strategic plans for the development of FOB.

Besides improving three major matters pointed out by ACBSP Council after the first self-study report, the second self-study report (in 2019):

•Focused resources to fulfill the accreditation for only one campus instead of two in 2017.

•Wrote the new report in the manner that answering (brief but provide enough information) all the questions required by ACBSP standards,

•Focused on evidence:

+ Provided English evidence to ensure that there is no barrier for assessors understand the institutions and programs.

+ Provided supporting evidence for each statement. Because, the assessors have to classify the information in the self-study report by various sources and ways, the University tries to provide as much evidence as possible in the platform of the ACBSP campus lab. So that assessors can gain a better understanding of the institutions and programs and make reasonable reviews and comments

+ Updated the latest number and information so that the assessors know the latest situation and the improvement of the institutions and programs.

+ Technically, provided the evidence in PDF format so that assessors can view via the platform's support. Other types of evidence files may force the assessors to download them and view on their own computer or laptop. This kind of action also cause some problems related to the institution and program's information security.

•Was reviewed several times by both FOB's managers and the institution management board. These top managers were in charge of ensuring the content of the report which must be consistent and convey the message of the institutions and FOB.

Additionally, this second phrase, one quality specialist of the University participated in the task force. This specialist ensured the self-study report approach to the nature of the assessment (what actually the assessment standards and the assessors want to know about the program) and provided clear and comprehensive data of all activities of FOB in the context of the X University.

The second self-study report was also honest about the weaknesses of the program in comparison with the requirements of ACBSP standards. However, it was a chance for the FOB's managers

to know their Business Administration program and to commit suitable actions or plans for improvement in the future.

With numerous improvements had been done and a lot of commitments in the future, the self-study report was accepted for an on-site visit and the Business Administration of the X University' FOB achieved the ACBSP accreditation status.

3.3 Further Actions towards Continuous Improvement

This achievement is driving forces for the FOB in particular and the X University in the general having actions to maintain the strengths and improve the shortcoming in order to continuously improve training quality of not only Business Administration program but also other business programs of the FOB. Some main improvement actions could be mentioned as following:

- Developing a process in order to evaluate and improve strategic targets to reflect changes in the internal and external environment.
- Improving the effectiveness of FOB's strategic planning process.
- Tracking the implementation of FOB's strategic, especially in monitoring and deployment of quality human resources by various kinds of data to ensure the effective and efficient accomplishment of the plans.
- Reallocating the faculty loads to maintain the balance among duties of the faculty members.
- Tracking the stakeholder survey's results to have timely improvements as well as suitable policies to meet stakeholder's needs. The data collecting from stakeholder is recommended to be used in a meaningful way to improve program offerings and promote student learning in the future.
- Continuously improving teaching and learning activities, assessment methods and the usage of academic KPI.
- Enhancing the quality of science research works of FOB faculty members and students.
- Effectively deploying the internal and external assessment on the program level to improve teaching quality.
- Widely communicating the FOB's information to stakeholders including its strategies through durations, assessment results, faculty and student activities, etc.
- Enhancing internationalization and international academic mobility of faculty members and students.

There are many shortcomings and many activities of FOB are not good to meet the requirements of ACBSP, but accreditation is a continuous and long-term process, the FOB understand that ACBSP wishes to receive commitments and practical actions of educational institutions. By demonstrating leadership commitment to the continuous improvement of teaching and learning quality and the actual actions to implement those commitments, the FOB in particular still has the opportunity to be assessed and accredited by a reputable educational accreditation organization such as ACBSP.

Through the practice of the X University in applying for ACBSP accreditation, the authors hope that other higher institutions could understand the simple process of accreditation, especially for ACBSP accreditation. The authors also try to give as much as possible some matters that FOB faced with so that other institutions and faculties could visualize some obstacles they have to deal with in the journey of accreditation.

In case that the institutions do not practice ACBSP accreditation, they could draw some lessons from the X University's experience as following:

- Understand the criteria;
- Understand actual situations of your institution;
- Be brave for making changes for improvement;
- Be honest and be brief (but provide enough information) in providing self-study reports as well as attached evidences.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Our thanks to ACM SIGCHI for allowing us to modify templates they had developed.

The authors thanks to ACBSP taskforce of the FOB, the X University for providing us reports of ACBSP accreditation of the FOB.

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